

Prawns, lobsters, and crabs

Crustaceans are an important group of marine animals that live in all oceans but are very common in shallow coastal seas. They have jointed, hard-shelled bodies like those of insects, and range from big, heavily armored types such as lobsters and crabs to the delicate, shrimplike krill and tiny copepods that form much of the oceanic zooplankton.



JOINTED BODIES

Most crustaceans have bodies like this prawn, with a head, a chain of body segments, and several pairs of legs specialized for different jobs. All the body parts are supported by a hard outer shell (the exoskeleton) made of a tough material called chitin, similar to your fingernails. The rigid segments are linked by mobile joints.

DRIFTING LARVAE

All crustaceans lay eggs. The eggs of crabs, for example, hatch as tiny larvae that live in the open ocean. They drift in the plankton, where they feed alongside small adult crustaceans such as copepods. Larvae go through many growth stages, shedding their skin each time and changing shape. Eventually, they change into small adults, which settle on the seabed.



▲ CRAB LARVA

Crab larvae spread far beyond the home range of their parents by drifting in the plankton and then settling in distant seas.

HEAVY ARMOR

The external skeleton of some crustaceans, including lobsters, crabs, and crayfish, is strengthened with chalky minerals to form a thick, very hard armor. This gives them protection from their enemies.

The exoskeleton's strength also allows some of these animals to have powerful claws for crushing their prey.

► EUROPEAN LOBSTER

The heavy shell of this lobster weighs it down, forcing it to live on the seabed where it hunts animals such as crabs and starfish.



Tail fan can be used for swimming

Body has armored segments

Long antennae sense prey in the dark

Thinner and more flexible chitin forms the joints, allowing the lobster to move its body

Smaller claw has sharp edges and is used for cutting prey